

AI Screens 90% of Job Applications as Work Trials and LinkedIn DMs Make a Comeback

TL;DR

- ▶ AI now touches nearly every stage of hiring — 90% of US employers screen applications with AI, and nearly two-thirds of job seekers say they've been interviewed by an AI bot, even though most hiring managers can't actually spot AI-written applications.
- ▶ With AI-polished résumés flooding applicant pools, more employers are turning to paid work trials to genuinely vet candidates — about two-thirds already use some form of skill-based hiring for entry-level roles.
- ▶ Morning Brew's own talent chief says referrals drive 8 of 10 hires, and job seekers get better odds cold-DMing mid-level employees on LinkedIn than reaching for the top.

AI NEWS *the news — then what it means for you*

AI now touches nearly every stage of the hiring funnel — and most managers can't tell. Job seekers increasingly use AI to write résumés and cover letters, get screened by AI-powered applicant tracking systems, are interviewed by AI bots, and undergo AI background checks. A Stanford study found 90% of US employers now use AI in screening, and Greenhouse data shows nearly two-thirds of job seekers say they've been interviewed by an AI bot. Yet a Software Finder survey found 60% of hiring managers believe they can spot AI-written applications, while only about 25% actually can — and the average job posting now draws 243 applications versus 89 three years ago.

What it means for you: Relevant to any hiring-process or workforce-advisory work: naive AI screening is likely both over-filtering good candidates and under-catching AI-generated ones. Worth raising with clients leaning on AI ATS tools without validating their actual detection accuracy.

Source: Hiring Brew (Morning Brew)

Paid work trials are making a comeback as AI-polished résumés flood applicant pools. More employers are testing candidates with real work before hiring — anywhere from a short off-site task to a full week in-office (trials must be paid if the work benefits the company). About two-thirds of companies now use some form of skill-based hiring for entry-level roles, per a 2025 NACE survey.

PM angle: Directly relevant — skill-based hiring and work-trial design sits squarely in workforce-strategy consulting territory, especially for clients rethinking screening funnels flooded by AI-generated applications.

Conversation starter: *Some companies are running week-long paid work trials instead of just interviewing — worth floating to any client rethinking their screening funnel?*

Source: Hiring Brew (Morning Brew)

Morning Brew's own talent chief says referrals — and the right LinkedIn DM — beat cold applying. Lily Mittman, VP of Talent Acquisition, says about 8 of 10 hires at the company come through internal referrals. Her advice for job seekers without a direct connection: target a mid-level employee on LinkedIn rather than a senior one — they get fewer inbound messages and are more likely to respond, especially where a referral bonus creates mutual incentive.

PM angle: Useful for our own recruiting and practice growth — referral-based outreach and targeting mid-level employees over senior ones is a cheap, concrete tactic worth testing.

Conversation starter: *Apparently the smart LinkedIn move is DMing mid-level folks, not the VP — anyone tried that for referrals?*

Source: Hiring Brew (Morning Brew)

A field guide to 2026's LinkedIn hiring vocabulary. Job-hugging: staying put in your current role through the hiring slowdown. Lily-padding: hopping role-to-role, sometimes across industries, to build skills toward a senior role (can raise red flags with employers). Career catfishing: candidates exaggerating qualifications or ghosting after accepting a job — or employers misrepresenting the role/culture. Doomjobbing: compulsively mass-applying for a dopamine hit, often ineffective.

PM angle: No direct relevance to your work, general awareness only.

Conversation starter: *Have you heard 'job-hugging'? Apparently staying put is the new hiring-slowdown strategy.*

Source: Hiring Brew (Morning Brew)